

“Next year their **lands will be taken**, for in war we can take them, **and rightfully**, too.”

WILLIAM T. SHERMAN IN A LETTER TO MAJOR R. M. SAWYER, JANUARY 31, 1864

The ravaged South

Half of the South's farm machinery had been destroyed along with hundreds of miles of railroad track. Additionally, large portions of Richmond, Mobile, Columbia, and Atlanta were damaged by fire. The “hard hand of war” fell unevenly on the Confederacy and those hardest hit were in the path of Sherman's March or Sheridan's raid in the Shenandoah Valley. Republican politician and German émigré Carl Schurz saw the devastation of the march and wrote that South Carolina “looked for many miles like a broad black streak of ruin and desolation—the fences all gone; lonesome smoke stacks, surrounded by dark heaps of ashes and cinders, marking the spots where human habitations had stood; the fields along the road wildly overgrown by weeds.” This was not the norm, however, and in other parts of the South, the Union army acted with more restraint.

The economic impact of the conflict was felt long after the fighting ended. Manufacturing and transportation had largely recovered by the 1870s, but agriculturally the South would remain a stagnant region of relative poverty for decades to come.